

19 CAN/ COULD

Can and Could: Ability

	Affirmative	Negative
Present	I can play the drums.	I can't play the piano.
Past	Ali could speak German and English.	He couldn't speak Japanese.

We use **can/can't** + base form to talk about ability in the present. We use **could/couldn't** to talk about ability in the past. The verb form stays the same for I, you, he, she, it, we, and they.

Exercises

19.1 Fill in the blanks with **can**, **can't**, **could**, or **couldn't** to complete each sentence correctly.

- 👉 When I was young, I _____ (ride) a bicycle, but now I _____.
- 👉 Sarah _____ (play) the piano very well now, but she _____ (play) it when she was five.
- 👉 They _____ (speak) French when they lived in Paris, but now they _____ (understand) it only a little.

 Last year, we _____ (travel) abroad due to the pandemic, but now we _____ (visit) other countries again.

 I _____ (run) a marathon when I was 18, but now I _____ (do) it anymore.

 _____ (you/cook) when you were a child?

 Tahir _____ (swim) very well now, but he _____ (swim) when he was younger.

 She _____ (read) books all day now because she has free time, but last year, she _____ (find) any time to read.

19.2 Write three sentences about abilities you **could** or **couldn't** do in the past and three sentences about abilities you can or can't do now.

 When I was young, I could ride a bicycle, but now I can't.

 Sarah can play the piano very well now, but she couldn't play it when she was five.

 _____

 _____

 _____

Can and Could: Permission & Request

We use **can** or **can't** to give or refuse permission.



You can come in now!

We use **can** or **could** to ask for permission.



Could I see the menu, please?

We use **can** or **could** to make requests. **Could** is more formal and politer than **can**.



Can you tidy your room now, please?



Could you open the door, please?

19.3

Match the questions with the answers a-f. Listen and check your answers. Practise in pairs.

Can you tell me the time, please?

d

Could you help me with my homework, please?

Can I use your ruler?

Could I see your photos?

Can I have a sandwich, please?

Can you wait for me, please?

a. OK. What's the problem?

b. Yes, sure. Here they are

c. No, you can't. Sorry. I need it.

d. Yes. It's 6 o'clock.

e. OK, but hurry up!

f. Yes, sure. Cheese or egg?